On 15 July, a newspaper carried Moolgaokar's views on his preference for successor saying that the ailing chairman had 'thrown his weight in favour' of Ratan.

As the days passed, Moolgaokar's health took a turn for the worse. He was unable to chair meetings and Ratan regularly deputed for him. But his indisposition did not stop Moolgaokar from striving to ensure that Ratan, and not Mody, would succeed him. Rumours also reached Bombay House that Moolgaokar would submit his resignation. But not many expected it to be a simple transition.

It was 9 December 1988 and Ratan was going about his work as usual. He was busy learning how to operate computers. But he knew that later in the day, he would have to attend the TELCO board meeting. Then he received an unexpected call. It was from JRD. There was a sense of annoyed urgency in his voice. He said: 'Come and meet me without loss of time.'

Ratan did not understand why he was being so urgently summoned, but he could guess that there was something unusual going on. He went straight to the chairman's room. He was surprised to see JRD so much unlike his usual self, 'looking stressed, his face was long', he recalls.

JRD said, without much ado, 'Sumant has stepped down and he has named you as his successor.' Ratan replied, 'You seem very worried and upset about it.' JRD responded, 'Yes, it was promised to Russi.'

Ratan was surprised. The sudden admission did not fluster him, though it was somewhat unnerving. Regaining his composure, he shot back, 'Then let it go to Russi. It is not something that I asked for.'

JRD replied that he would have to speak to Mody. Ratan left the room, saying: 'Then you may not want me in the room.' Before he left, he did not forget to add that he was willing to go by anything the chairman would demand of him. But he also made it clear that he was not willing to compromise on his principles and accept the appointment as deputy chairman 'on the back of a press statement' insulting the veteran Moolgaokar.

Mody's Last Effort

Mody was already aware of the developments taking place in Bombay and the scheduled TELCO board meeting. He landed in the city, hoping to make